

# The end of the grudge

*In a memory of Sergeant Briggs and Blackhoof Witherspine*

The tavern had no particular virtue except that it was warm and the cards were honest, which was two more virtues than most places Briggs frequented.

He had left Blackhoof at the gate with no particular instructions, which centaur had interpreted as an invitation to follow him at a distance and spend the evening in the tavern. When the innkeeper had appeared with a jug of local mead — golden, smelling of something floral and expensive — Blackhoof had accepted it without ceremony and settled into the straw with the uncomplicated satisfaction of someone who had found his evening.

Briggs had found a table. Three local men, with the expressions of people who played cards because there was nothing else to do and had gotten good at it. He sat. He played.

The ale arrived without his asking, which he noted and did not think about further, because the game was at an interesting point and the ale was cold and the evening was going well. He drank.

\*\*\*

The walk back should have taken a few minutes.

By the time Briggs reached the first bend in the road, the ten minutes had become something elastic and unreliable, and the road itself had developed a tendency to move slightly to the left when he wasn't watching it. He stopped. Stood still. Made a deliberate inventory of his own condition.

His hands were present. His legs were functional but consulting each other about directions. His vision was intact except for the edges, which were doing something he didn't have a word for — not blurring, exactly, more like the world had developed a slight additional depth that hadn't been there before.

*I can't be drunk from a few ales! Poisoned!* he thought, with the flat clarity of a man arriving at an unwelcome conclusion.

He understood the mechanics of poison the way he understood most things — practically, from experience. He knew what a blade felt like, what an arrow felt like, what exhaustion and fear and cold felt like. This was different. This was inside, which meant it was already done, already moving, and there was nothing to block or deflect or outmaneuver. Just the drug in his blood doing its patient work.

He kept walking, because stopping was the alternative and stopping felt like losing.

The shapes came out of the treeline before he'd made it another fifty yards.

Three of them. The way they moved sold them, too loose, too casual, the movement of men who were confident in their numbers. They had blades. They had the particular expressions of men who had been paid to do something and were doing it.

Behind them, at the treeline's edge, a fourth shape. Smaller. Standing with its arms crossed and watching. Briggs commanded his eyes to focus.

Shades step aside for a second, shape got brighter and Briggs recognised - it was Tusk!

Tusk recently released from duty without honors. Tusk wanted him dead by ambush. Tusk wanted him to be guilty from stealing - and backfired with the last attempt.

Exmilitary looked back at him with the expression of a man who had arranged something correctly and was waiting for it to conclude.

Briggs drew his blade.

His hand was steadier than his legs, which was something. The first man came in fast and Briggs moved — wrong direction, half a step too far, the world tilting.

He didn't hear Blackhoof coming.

Nobody heard centaur coming until it was too late — four hooves on a dirt road could be silent when they needed to be. What Briggs heard was the result: a sound like a small thunderstorm arriving at close range, followed by the particular noise of two men leaving the ground simultaneously and landing with the conviction of people who would not be getting up immediately.

The third man turned toward the sound.

Blackhoof hit him with a shoulder charge that removed him from the situation entirely and deposited him in the ditch with the efficiency of someone tidying.

He took a blade across his left forearm in the process — shallow, more insult than injury — and ignored it with the focused attention of a creature that had decided the blade was someone else's problem.

Then Tusk moved.

Goblin came out of the treeline fast, faster than Briggs would have expected, with the desperate energy of a man who had run out of arrangements and was down to the only thing left. He had a short sword.

"This time, you're mine!" Tusk said, and his voice had something in it that wasn't quite anger and wasn't quite grief. "You gnomish slug!"

Briggs turned to face him.

The world tilted. He stayed upright thanks to pure stubbornness, because he had been doing that his entire life and was not going to stop because of something got in his ale.

Tusk swung.

It was not a good swing. It had force behind it but no real strength, the swing of a man who had spent his career behind ledgers. Briggs moved — barely, just enough — and felt it pass close enough to matter, and then he was inside the arc and the distance was nothing and the fight lasted approximately four more seconds and had only one possible conclusion.

He felt the moment Tusk stopped.

Not heard. Felt — the sudden absence of resistance, the weight shifting.

He looked at Tusk's face in the dark and watched the light in it do what light did, eventually, in everyone — not dramatically, not all at once, but in the specific way of something that has decided it is finished.

Goblin's body hit the ground.

Gnome followed it. The road received him without ceremony, and the night was suddenly very quiet.

\*\*\*

Blackhoof appeared behind his shoulder.

"Briggs."

"Mm."

"Can you stand."

He could. It took longer than usual and required Blackhoof's arm as an intermediary, and the world continued its opinion about directions for another few minutes, but he got there.

Blackhoof looked at him in the dark with the careful assessment of a man checking for damage.

"You're not bleeding," he said.

"No."

"What happened? One moment you were gambling, another moment you were gone!"

"The ale."

"No, I had the mead," Blackhoof said, with the tone of a man noting something that had turned out to be significant.

"Blacky!" Briggs looked at his own hand for a moment. Steady enough. "I had an ale. It was the only thing I had. They have poisoned me."

"Innkeeper?"

"Tusk's man, probably. Or paid for the evening." Briggs' breath was still heavy.

Blackhoof looked at the road, at the three shapes in the ditch, at the fourth shape that was not getting up. "Well, what is done is done," Blackhoof said. "Let's get you back."

\*\*\*

They walked slowly, which suited both of them — Blackhoof's forearm was making itself known in the way shallow wounds did when the evening cooled, and Briggs's legs were still conducting their independent negotiations with the road. They didn't speak much. The dark was quiet around them, the kind of quiet that came after things were finished.

Briggs walked and let his mind do what it did after battles — the flat, methodical inventory of what had happened and what it meant.

He thought about the spring campaign, three years ago. The swamp. Ironhoof pulling a bullywug off a supply officer who had looked at them afterward like they'd done something to him.

He thought about a dice game and a man eating at the common pot for a week.

He thought about a delivery and a route that had been watched.

None of it had been intended. Not the humiliation, not the rescue, not the way Tusk had carried it all and built something out of it in the dark. Briggs had simply moved through the world the way he always moved through it — practically, without sentiment — and Tusk had taken each incidental wound and sharpened it into something deliberate.

Briggs was tired.

Not tired of a long evening or a hard fight. The other kind — the kind that had been accumulating for a while now and was beginning to make its weight known in the mornings.

Three months, he thought, and the thought arrived with less resistance than usual.

Beside him, Blackhoof walked in companionable silence, with that smile, mead apparently left some pleasure memories, entirely unaware that anything had shifted.

Which was, Briggs thought, exactly as it should be.

"Your arm," he said.

"It's fine."

"Let someone look at it when we're back."

"Yes, sergeant." The tone of a man who intended to do no such thing.

Briggs said nothing further. The gate appeared ahead of them in the dark, torchlit, ordinary, the camp behind it doing its usual evening business as if nothing had changed, which for everyone inside it, nothing had.

He walked through it and let the familiar sounds close around him, and put the road behind him, and thought: the contract ends in three months.

And then, for the first time in a long time, he let himself think about what may come after.

